



General Assembly

Distr.: General
18 June 2025

English only

Human Rights Council

Fifty-ninth session

16 June–11 July 2025

Agenda item 3

**Promotion and protection of all human rights, civil,
political, economic, social and cultural rights,
including the right to development**

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The Secretary-General has received the following written statement which is circulated in accordance with Economic and Social Council resolution 1996/31.

[25 May 2025]

* Issued as received, in the language of submission only.



Eliminating Extreme Poverty by Realizing the Right to Development

Introduction

Our organization underscores the urgent necessity to realize the right to development as a foundational pillar for eliminating extreme poverty and achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). We also express deep concern regarding the detrimental impact of unilateral coercive measures (UCMs) on socio-economic rights and development capacities in affected states.

Recent Global Poverty Trends

According to the World Bank in 2023, approximately 659 million people, or about 8.5% of the global population, lived below the international poverty line of \$2.15 per day. (1) The Special Rapporteur on Extreme Poverty has emphasized that poverty extends beyond income deprivation, reflecting systemic denial of capabilities and opportunities, particularly where international structural barriers, including sanctions, impede national development efforts. (2)

The Right to Development: Legal Framework

The Declaration on the Right to Development recognizes that every human person is entitled to participate in, contribute to, and enjoy economic, social, cultural, and political development. (3) This right is fundamentally connected to poverty eradication, as it frames poverty as a lack of income and a denial of the ability to benefit from development processes. According to the Declaration on the Right to Development, development must be people-centered, emphasizing equality of opportunity, social justice, and global justice as core principles. (4) The Declaration imposes both internal and external obligations on States: internally, States must formulate national development policies ensuring equitable access to resources, education, health, and employment; externally, they must cooperate internationally to create favorable conditions for development, including financial, technological, and trade support. (5) Consequently, poverty eradication under the right to development requires a rights-based approach that guarantees participation of marginalized populations in decision-making, equitable and distribution of development benefits.

The Adverse Impact of Unilateral Coercive Measures

Currently, about 30 countries are subject to unilateral sanctions, affecting nearly 29% of the global population. (6) The Special Rapporteur on UCMs has documented that significant negative economic impacts of sanctions, including disruptions to trade, financial transactions, and access to essential goods like food and medicine, can exacerbate poverty. (7) For instance, the inflation rate in the Islamic Republic of Iran and Zimbabwe, respectively, reached 44.6 percent in 2023 and 104.7 percent in 2022. (8)

Governance of Financial Institutions and Poverty Outcomes

International financial institutions, especially the Bretton Woods Institutions, play a pivotal role in shaping poverty outcomes through their structural design and governance. The current structure of such institutions often limits the voice and representation of developing countries, which constrains their ability to influence policies that directly affect poverty reduction efforts. This imbalance can perpetuate inequalities by prioritizing the interests of wealthier nations, resulting in financing mechanisms that are less accessible or responsive to the urgent needs of developing countries.

Moreover, the complexity of International financial institutions' lending sometimes restricts timely access to affordable finance, thereby limiting countries' fiscal space to invest in essential public services such as health, education, and social protection.

Development Finance and International Gaps

Development finance plays a critical role in addressing extreme poverty and realizing the right to development. However, significant international gaps remain in the availability and accessibility of financial resources for low- and middle-income countries. These gaps disproportionately affect vulnerable populations and hinder progress toward the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). The Green Climate Fund (GCF), a key mechanism supporting climate adaptation and mitigation in developing States, had mobilized only \$11.4 billion in pledges as of 2023, far below the agreed target of \$100 billion annually by 2020. (9) Similarly, the Loss and Damage Fund, established at COP28, has received initial pledges totaling \$700 million, compared to estimated annual needs exceeding \$400 billion. (10) Such financing gaps, compounded by structural barriers including sanctions, impede access to essential financial resources and obstruct the fulfillment of international cooperation obligations under the right to development.

We commend the Special Rapporteur for his continued focus on the structural and international dimensions of poverty. Eradicating poverty demands not only domestic commitment but also international solidarity, respect for the right to development, and removal of barriers-including unilateral sanctions that perpetuate deprivation. We urge the Human Rights Council to take decisive action to advance these priorities.

Recommendations

We call on the Human Rights Council, Member States, and international institutions to:

- Cease the application of unilateral coercive measures that undermine poverty reduction, human rights, and the right to development;
- Strengthen international cooperation by fulfilling obligations under international law, including financial, technological, and capacity-building support;
- Fully fund the Green Climate Fund and Loss and Damage mechanisms, ensuring equitable resource flows to countries most affected by poverty and climate change;
- Mandate regular assessment of the humanitarian impacts of sanctions to ensure compliance with international human rights obligations;
- Prioritize poverty eradication in global policy frameworks, recognizing it as a cross-cutting issue under human rights law and the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.
- International financial institutions, including Multilateral Development Banks and Bretton Woods Institutions, undergo comprehensive governance reforms to ensure equitable representation and inclusive decision-making that reflect the growing voice and needs of developing and emerging economies

1) March 2023 global poverty update from the World Bank: the challenge of estimating poverty in the pandemic.

2) UN Human Rights Council, Report of the Special Rapporteur on extreme poverty and human rights, A/HRC/53/33.

3) UN General Assembly, Declaration on the Right to Development, Resolution A/RES/41/128, 4 December 1986, Art. 1(1).

4) Ibid., Arts. 2(1), 8(1).

5) <https://lawexplores.com/global-poverty-and-the-right-to-development/>.

6) <https://www.castellum.ai/insights/2024-sanctions-year-in-review>.

7)UN Human Rights Council, Special Rapporteur on the Negative Impact of Unilateral Coercive Measures on the Enjoyment of Human Rights, Alena Douhan, Monitoring and assessment of the impact of unilateral sanctions and overcompliance on human rights, A/HRC/57/55, para. 66.

8)Ibid., para. 48.

9)UNFCCC Standing Committee on Finance. (2023). Biennial Assessment and Overview of Climate Finance Flows.

10)Climate Policy Initiative, Global Landscape of Climate Finance, Retrieved from <https://www.greenclimate.fund/publications>